

Comments for Planning Application DM2025/01591

Application Summary

Application Number: DM2025/01591

Address: Ambulance Station Dorset Road Belmont SM2 6JH

Proposal: Change of use from Sui Generis (Ambulance Station) to mixed use Classes F1 (Places of Worship) and F2 (Community Hub) involving the erection of a part one, part two storey front and side extension, increase in height to part of building and provision of cycle and refuse stores.

Case Officer: Polly Davidson

Customer Details

Name: Mr Mohammed Shadab

Address: 33 Furzedown Road Sutton SM2 5QF

Comment Details

Commenter Type:

Stance: Customer made comments in support of the Planning Application

Comment Reasons:

Comment: I am writing to formally record my strong support for planning application DM2025/01591.

The proposal to change the use of the former ambulance station into a community hub and place of worship represents a thoughtful and policy-aligned redevelopment of a currently vacant and underutilised site. At present, the site is hard-surfaced, inactive, and contributes little to the vitality or appearance of the surrounding area. Bringing it back into productive use would enhance the streetscape, improve natural surveillance, and create a focal point for positive community activity - all on previously developed land, with no loss of greenfield or open space.

From a planning perspective, this is a sustainable form of development. It makes efficient use of an existing urban site, reduces pressure to develop elsewhere, and introduces a use that is locally accessible by foot and public transport. Community facilities are most effective when embedded within neighbourhoods, and this proposal achieves exactly that.

Parking and traffic concerns have been raised, but the evidence submitted does not substantiate claims of significant harm. The Transport Statement identified 269 parking spaces in the surrounding area, with only 134 occupied at peak time, demonstrating substantial spare capacity. The anticipated demand associated with the proposed use is modest in comparison.

It is also important to consider the historical baseline. The former ambulance station had 21 on-site parking spaces. The proposed redevelopment removes these and, crucially, will also result in the removal of the existing yellow keep-clear markings near the entrance. This will release

additional kerbside capacity currently unavailable to residents. In practical terms, the kerbside position is likely to improve rather than worsen.

Some objections have linked the proposal to potential congestion during school-run periods. However, the timing evidence shows a gap of over two hours between the end of Friday prayer changeover and the start of the afternoon school run. The assertion of a direct clash is therefore not supported by the schedule.

Beyond the transport considerations, the social value of this proposal should be given significant weight. Social isolation is widely recognised as a risk factor for depression, cardiovascular disease, and cognitive decline, particularly among elderly residents and new mothers. A local, accessible community hub offering educational activities, wellbeing sessions, youth engagement, and social support directly addresses these challenges. It would provide a safe and inclusive space where residents can build connections, access resources, and participate in structured programmes that enhance overall wellbeing.

This part of the borough is comparatively underserved in terms of multi-functional community facilities. The application demonstrates clear demand, and the mixed model of faith and broader community use ensures that the benefits extend beyond any single group. The facility would serve as an anchor institution within the neighbourhood, encouraging civic participation and fostering social cohesion.

Importantly, planning decisions must be grounded in material considerations and evidence rather than perception. On its planning merits, this application is strong. It aligns with local and national policy supporting the retention and enhancement of community facilities, makes effective use of brownfield land, and is supported by technical assessments that demonstrate its impacts are acceptable and manageable.

For these reasons, I respectfully request that the London Borough of Sutton approve planning application DM2025/01591.